

CORE FORMULA

Shared anchor + difference-respect + next cooperative move. -> "As [accurate shared role/goal], we both care about [outcome]. I know we may differ on [route/timing]. Could we [next small step]?" -> **Short form:** "We both care about [X]. We may differ on [Y]. Let's [next step]." -> **Minimum viable:** "We're trying to protect the same thing from different angles." -> **High-safety:** "I may be over-reading the common ground, but it seems we both care about [X]. Does that fit?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one small, true "we": "We both care about [shared outcome], even if we see the route differently."

BEST FOR

- Team discussions where people share an outcome but differ on process.
- Social conversations where a light shared category can create ease.
- Conflict repair when both people still care about respect or the relationship.
- Stakeholder conversations where common purpose is being lost in the detail.
- Cross-functional work where each side feels the other does not understand its constraints.
- Community, family, or friend contexts where a real shared history can be named gently.

PHRASE BANK

Quick same-side openers · Short one-liners

- "Same side here."
- "We both want this to work."
- "I think we're after the same thing."
- "Same goal, different route."
- "We're on the same team on this one."
- "I don't think we're actually opposed here."
- "We both care about getting this right."

Social / rapport · Warm, low-pressure

- "We're both trying to make this less awkward, I think."
- "As two people who care about keeping this friendly, can we reset?"
- "We both know this group can get intense; I'd like to keep it easy."
- "We've both been through that version of the learning curve."
- "We both want to leave this feeling good about it."
- "I reckon we both value this more than being right."
- "We're both a bit out of our depth here, and that's fine."
- "We both showed up wanting the same kind of evening, I think."

Work / handoffs · Meetings and delivery

- "We're on the same side of wanting a clean handoff."
- "As the people responsible for the customer experience, we both have a stake in this."
- "We're protecting different risks, but the outcome is shared."
- "Our shared standard is a decision people can actually execute."
- "We both own how this lands, even if we came at it differently."
- "As the two closest to this, we're best placed to get it right."
- "We both want a version that survives contact with real users."

- "Same brief on my end: something the team can ship without rework."

Conflict / same-side · De-escalation

- "I don't think we're enemies here; I think we're protecting different concerns."
- "We both seem to want respect in this conversation. Let me slow down."
- "Same-side note: I want the decision to work, not just my version to win."
- "We both care enough to be direct. Let's make the directness useful."
- "I'd rather we solved this together than scored points off each other."
- "We're both frustrated, and I don't think it's actually with each other."
- "I don't want to win this and lose the working relationship."
- "We both want out of this loop. Let's find the exit together."

High-pressure / time · Deadline and stakes

- "We share the need to move quickly without creating a bigger cleanup."
- "We're both under time pressure, so let's separate facts from guesses."
- "The shared goal is a safe decision with the information we have."
- "We both need the next step to be executable today."
- "We're both trying to avoid the same mess here."
- "Neither of us wants to be back here next week redoing this."
- "We both want to move fast; let's make sure it's the right fast."

Boundary-safe / optionality · Invites correction

- "I don't want to overstate the common ground, but I think we both care about this."
- "Correct me if this doesn't fit: the shared concern seems to be quality."
- "I'm not asking you to agree with me; I'm naming the part that seems shared."
- "Tell me if I'm over-reading it, but it sounds like we want the same outcome."
- "You don't have to accept the framing — does the underlying goal fit, though?"
- "If 'we' is too strong, say so; I only mean we both want this settled."
- "Does that shared goal fit, or am I reaching?"

Digital / text · Threads and chat

- "We may be typing past each other. I think we both want the same end state."
- "Same goal on my end: clear next steps and no surprise rework."
- "I read us as aligned on the problem, split on the fix."
- "For the group: our shared priority seems to be speed without avoidable mess."
- "Reading back, I think we agree on the what and differ on the how."
- "Genuine question, not a gotcha: are we actually after different things here?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "Come on, we're all team players here." Uses identity as pressure and implies dissent is disloyalty.
Better: "I know we all want the launch to go well, even though we're split on timing."
Best: "We're both protecting the launch from different risks — you're protecting customer trust, I'm protecting schedule exposure. Could we compare the smallest release that protects both?"
- Weak: "As friends, you should understand."
Better: "Because we care about the friendship, I want to say this cleanly."
Best: "I value the friendship, and I don't want this to turn into hidden resentment. Can I name what felt off and hear your read too?"
- Weak: "People like us don't complain."
Better: "We both care about handling this constructively."
Best: "We both seem to care about being constructive — and that includes naming what isn't working without making it personal."

DECISION TREE

If You don't have a real shared anchor yet

Discover common ground first; don't manufacture a "we".

"What matters most to you in how this turns out?"

If The anchor is real but might feel assumed or loaded

Use a softer outcome frame and invite correction.

"Tell me if this doesn't fit — it seems like we both want [X]."

If They're resisting or setting a boundary

Don't use shared-identity language; validate and respect the boundary.

"Fair enough — I'll speak only for myself here."

If The moment is tense

Use a short same-side phrase plus a difference-respecting clause.

"We're not enemies here; we're protecting different concerns."

If They only partly accept the frame

Ask for correction before you build on it.

"Does that shared goal fit, or am I over-reading it?"

If They accept the frame

Move to a concrete next step that fits the need — ask, summary, choice, or repair.

"Good — could we agree the owner and the next step now?"

SCENARIOS

Team disagreement

Name the shared outcome and keep both risks legitimate; don't use unity to end the debate. — "We're protecting different risks, but we share the goal of a decision people can execute."

Friend tension

Anchor on the relationship as the reason to speak, not as leverage. — "Because we both care about the friendship, I'd rather name this than let it go weird."

Client conversation

Point at their outcome first, then own your specific concern. — "We both want this to land well with your stakeholders. My concern is the handoff risk."

Online discussion

Separate agreement on the problem from disagreement on the fix. — "I think we're aligned on the problem and split on the fix."

Family logistics

Name the shared want, then move to one concrete decision. — "We all want the day to be easier, not more tense. Could we settle the pickup plan first?"

Leadership pressure

Use shared accountability to hold two needs at once, not to demand compliance. — "As the people accountable for this, we need both speed and a rollback path."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The shared identity is not true, or you are only assuming it.
- The other person is trying to establish a boundary.
- The phrase would land as forced intimacy.
- There is a significant power imbalance and "we" could mask pressure.
- You are tempted to use identity as leverage: "If you were really one of us..."
- The other person has explicitly rejected the label or the group frame.
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority over rapport.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the anchor

For five recent disagreements, write one true shared anchor for each — a goal, standard, concern, or constraint. Name

nothing you can't actually point to.

Day 2 — Build the sentence

Take three of those anchors and write the full formula for each: "We both care about [X]. We may differ on [Y]. Could we [next step]?"

Day 3 — Add optionality

Rewrite each sentence with one optionality marker — "I may be over-reading this, but..." or "Correct me if this doesn't fit..." — so the frame stays an invitation, not a claim.

Day 4 — Say it plain

Read each line aloud in a normal voice. Cut anything that sounds like corporate unity, forced intimacy, or pressure. Shorten to the smallest true "we".

Day 5 — Practise recovery

Have someone (or yourself) reply "Don't say we." Answer with a recovery line that drops the frame, keeps respect, and returns to the concrete issue.

Day 6 — Use it once, low-stakes

In a real but low-stakes conversation, use one same-side sentence and watch whether they soften, correct, or resist. Note which happened.

Day 7 — Use it under tension

In a genuinely tense conversation, name the smallest true anchor, add a difference-respecting clause, then offer one concrete next step. Afterwards, note where "we" eased things and where it risked sounding like pressure.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Was the shared identity or goal actually true?
- Did I avoid speaking for the other person too strongly?
- Did I leave room for disagreement?
- Did I follow the shared frame with a concrete next step?
- Did I avoid using "we" to hide my own responsibility?
- Would the phrase still feel respectful if they repeated it back to me?